

Pagoda in Burmese style, 9th–10th century

Gilded crown



Southeast Asia and the Middle East

The traditional architectural styles of Asia and the Middle East remained the same for centuries. Both were heavily influenced by religious belief: Buddhism and Hinduism in southern Asia, and Islam in the Middle East. The style of buildings was determined by climate, and the materials available to local builders. As early as the 7th century, wooden temples and monasteries were being built in China and Japan.

South and East Asia

Many of the distinctive features of this area's architecture originated in Buddhist India. An example is the multi-storeyed pagoda, a temple which seems to stretch towards Heaven. It was developed initially in Japan and China but was based on the spires found on early Indian temples. An important feature of many traditional Asian buildings is their imaginative roof forms.



Islamic architecture

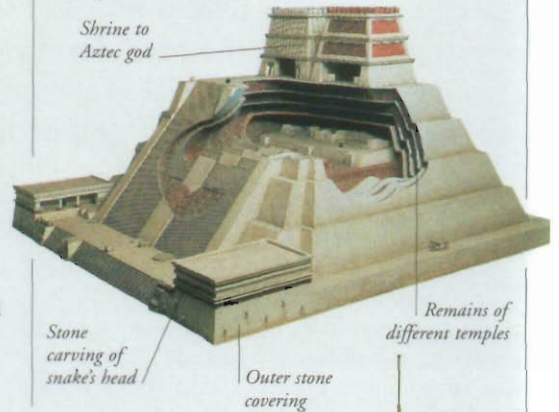
The most important buildings in Islamic countries are usually mosques and tombs. The mosque is the centre of a Muslim community, and provides space for group worship. It contains a prayer hall, often with a domed roof, and may also have a courtyard. A minaret, from which the faithful are called to prayer, is a typical feature.



Islamic decoration favours geometric patterns and calligraphy.

Early American civilizations

The Aztecs, who ruled in what is now Mexico from the 14th to 16th centuries, built stone pyramids to their gods. The remains of five separate temples have been found at Tenochtitlan, built one on top of the other as new rulers erected bigger temples on the same site.



Shrine to Aztec god

Stone carving of snake's head

Outer stone covering

Remains of different temples

Baroque and Neoclassical

The Baroque style emerged in early 17th-century Europe. It introduced buildings with ornate decoration, complex shapes, and dramatic lighting. It was followed by the Neoclassical style, which revived the more restrained Classical traditions. This was partly as a reaction to Baroque excess.



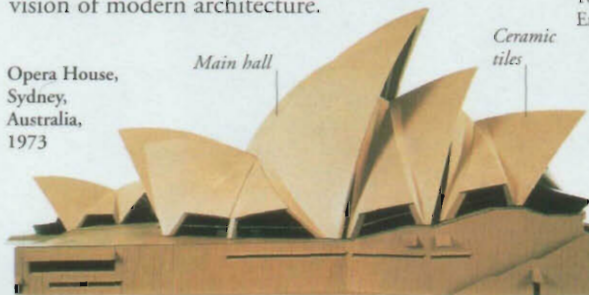
Greek-style portico

Neoclassical church, France, 1764

The 19th and 20th centuries

The development of new, very strong materials made it possible to construct buildings which were often highly original in style and owed little to the past. Helped by better technology, architects turned to glass, steel, and concrete to express their vision of modern architecture.

Opera House, Sydney, Australia, 1973



Main hall

Ceramic tiles

Very plain decoration

Limestone and granite facing

Interlocked vaults

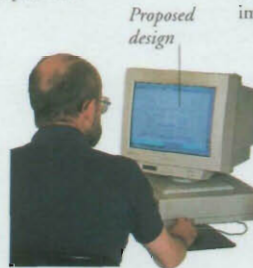
The dramatic profile of the Opera House dominates Sydney Harbour. The building's roof of interlocked vaults, made from reinforced concrete covered with gleaming tiles, resembles a ship in sail.

Skyscrapers

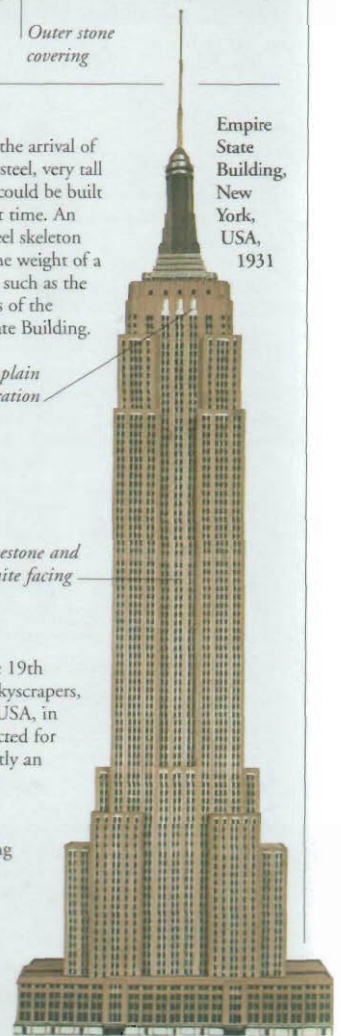
The invention of the lift during the 19th century made it practical to build skyscrapers, and the first appeared in Chicago, USA, in the 1880s. Today, most are constructed for large businesses: they convey perfectly an image of wealth, size, and strength.

Architects

An architect designs a building and oversees its construction. Successful architects become very well-known. Until recently, architects drew large numbers of plans to instruct builders and engineers. Much of this work is now carried out on computer.



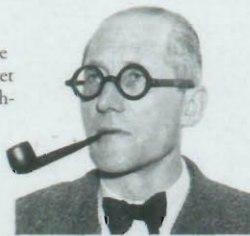
Proposed design



Empire State Building, New York, USA, 1931

Le Corbusier

Le Corbusier was the name used by the Swiss-French Charles Édouard Jeanneret (1887–1965), the most influential 20th-century architect. Le Corbusier promoted the use of new materials and construction techniques. His imaginative buildings favoured plain, often severe, geometric forms.



Timeline

2650 BC The Step Pyramid in Egypt is designed.

c.300 BC Buddhist temple mounds appear in India.

AD 82 Colosseum built in Rome. Dozens of stone arches support the walls of this stone arena.

690–850 Early Islamic buildings are designed around courtyards.

1100–1500 Gothic churches built in Europe.

c.1420 Renaissance begins in Italy; architects return to the elegant, ordered values of Classical builders.

19th century Industrial Revolution: mass-produced materials transform construction.

FIND OUT MORE

1920s International Modernism begins, typified by glass-and-steel towers and flat-roofed, white houses.

BUILDING AND CONSTRUCTION

1970s Postmodernism develops. It refers to past styles, in a humorous way. Strong colours are popular.

CHURCHES AND CATHEDRALS

1990s Eco-friendly architecture reflects environmental concerns about energy-saving and recycling.

CITIES

MOSQUES